Problems & solutions

A conversational idiom workbook: 10 phrases, each with a short conversation and four quick tasks. Do it online and check your answers, or print it and use the answer key at the end.

In this workbook

1. **it's on me**: It is my fault or my responsibility.
2. **kick in**: When something kicks in, it starts to work or take effect.
3. **the light bulb goes off**: You suddenly understand something or get a good idea.
4. **make it work**: To find a way to deal with a difficult situation and succeed anyway.
5. **next to impossible**: Almost impossible, extremely difficult.
6. **on top of that**: In addition to something already mentioned, often something else annoying or surprising.
7. **or else**: Used to say what bad thing will happen if you don't do something.
8. **put my foot down**: To firmly refuse to allow something, or to insist on a rule.
9. **settle for**: To accept something that is less good than what you really wanted.
10. **swap out**: To swap something out is to remove it and put a different one in its place.

How to use it: read the conversation out loud first, then do the four tasks. For the last task, answer out loud before you write, and try to use the phrase naturally.

it's on me

Expression | Level B1 | Casual

It is my fault or my responsibility.

Tip: Use it when you accept blame or take responsibility, often right after something goes wrong: 'Sorry, that's on me.' Careful: 'it's on me' can also mean 'I'm paying' (see 'the next round is on me'), so context matters.

Olena: Hi Kofi, did you get the email from the client? They say the files never arrived.

Kofi: Oh no. I think I attached the wrong folder yesterday.

Olena: Really? They need them before the meeting at three.

Kofi: I'm sorry, it's on me. I should have checked before I hit send.

Olena: Okay, thanks for being honest. Can you send the right files now?

Kofi: Doing it right now, and I'll call them to explain.

1. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "it's on me" mean?

- ○ A. It was my mistake and I take responsibility.
- ○ B. I am carrying it with me.
- ○ C. I will pay for it.
- ○ D. I am the one who is waiting for it.

2. Fill the gap

The printer ran out of paper because I forgot to order more, so _____.

3. Choose the best reply

Amira: *Our flight was delayed because we got to the airport so late.*

- ○ A. Yes, it's on me. I put it on the table in the hall.
- ○ B. Yes, it's on me. The airline is paying for everything.
- ○ C. Yes, it's on me. I should have left earlier.

4. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when something went wrong and you were the one responsible.

_____

_____

_____

kick in

Phrasal verb | Level B2 | Neutral

When something kicks in, it starts to work or take effect.

Tip: Use it for things that start working after a delay (medicine, heating, a backup system, a rule); the subject comes before it and no object follows: 'The heating kicks in at six.'

Amira: Is it still freezing in your flat?

Diego: A bit. The heating is on, but it's set to a timer.

Amira: So when does it come on?

Diego: Around six. Once it kicks in, the whole place warms up in half an hour.

Amira: Then put a jumper on until then. It's only twenty minutes away.

Diego: Good idea. I'm making tea in the meantime.

5. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "kicks in" mean?

- ○ A. becomes more expensive to use
- ○ B. starts working or taking effect
- ○ C. gets turned off for the night
- ○ D. breaks down suddenly

6. Fill the gap

I always feel a bit tired in the morning, but after my first coffee the energy _____ and I'm fine.

7. Choose the best reply

Ken: *I took the tablet an hour ago and my headache is still there.*

- ○ A. Give it a bit longer. It might not have kicked in yet.
- ○ B. Yes, it kicked in your headache very quickly.
- ○ C. Maybe you should kick in the tablet harder.

8. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you had to wait for something to start working, such as a new routine, a medicine, or a piece of technology.

the light bulb goes off

Idiom | Level B1 | Casual

You suddenly understand something or get a good idea.

Tip: Use it for a sudden moment of understanding, usually in the past tense: 'the light bulb went off'; add 'for me' or 'when I saw...' to say what triggered it.

Olena: Did you ever fix the Wi-Fi at your place?

Diego: Finally, yes. I kept restarting the router and nothing worked.

Olena: So what changed?

Diego: My neighbour mentioned her network name was almost the same as mine. Then the light bulb went off. I'd been connecting to hers the whole time.

Olena: Ha! No wonder it was so slow.

9. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'the light bulb went off' mean?

- ○ A. Diego's electricity stopped working.
- ○ B. Diego felt embarrassed in front of his neighbour.
- ○ C. Diego decided to buy a new router.
- ○ D. Diego suddenly understood what the problem was.

10. Fill the gap

I stared at the spreadsheet for an hour, and then the _____ when I noticed one column was in the wrong format.

11. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I couldn't work out why my plants kept dying, and then I realised I was watering them twice a day.*

- ○ A. Yes, I always turn the light bulb off when I leave the house.
- ○ B. Ah, so the light bulb went off, and now you know what to do differently.
- ○ C. Wow, the light bulb went off in your kitchen, so you should call an electrician.

12. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you were stuck on a problem and then suddenly understood how to solve it.

_____

_____

_____

make it work

Expression · Level B1 · Neutral

To find a way to deal with a difficult situation and succeed anyway.

Tip: Use it after a 'but' or 'even though' clause to say you'll succeed despite a limitation; it's often said as 'we'll make it work' or 'I'll make it work', and it works in formal speech too.

Amira: Did the hotel confirm the extra bed for Kofi?

Diego: No, they only have one room left, and it's tiny.

Amira: Oh no. Should we look for somewhere else?

Diego: It's the last weekend before the conference, and everything nearby is full.

Amira: Okay, we'll take turns on the sofa. We can make it work.

Diego: Fine by me. I'll tell them we're taking the room.

13. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "make it work" mean?

- ○ A. Change the plan completely and cancel the trip
- ○ B. Find a way to manage the difficult situation and still succeed
- ○ C. Build or repair something so that a machine works again
- ○ D. Do a lot of hard physical work to earn money

14. Fill the gap

We don't have much time before the deadline, but I think we can _____ if we split the tasks.

15. Choose the best reply

Olena: *The shop can't deliver the sofa until Friday, but your party is on Thursday.*

- ○ A. I'll make it work for a new job at the shop.
- ○ B. Don't worry, we'll borrow some chairs and make it work.
- ○ C. Yes, the sofa will make it work very well on Friday.

16. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you had to deal with a difficult situation with limited time or resources. What did you do?

next to impossible

Expression · Level B2 · Neutral

Almost impossible, extremely difficult.

Tip: Use it before an adjective or infinitive phrase: 'next to impossible to find' or 'next to impossible for us'; it sounds a little softer than 'impossible' because it leaves a tiny gap.

Olena: Did you manage to book a table for Saturday? It's Amira's birthday.

Diego: I tried five places. Everything is full.

Olena: Even the Italian place near the station?

Diego: Yes, it's next to impossible to get a table for ten on a weekend.

Olena: Then let's skip the restaurant. I can cook at my place.

Diego: That's a great idea. I'll bring dessert.

17. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'next to impossible' mean?

- ○ A. Impossible, but only for one specific day
- ○ B. Difficult at first but easy once you know how
- ○ C. Almost impossible; extremely difficult
- ○ D. Possible only at the next restaurant you try

18. Fill the gap

With the road closed for repairs, getting to the airport before 6 a.m. is _____.

19. Choose the best reply

Kofi: *I've been trying to reach the bank all morning, but the phone line is always busy.*

- ○ A. I know, getting through to them is next to impossible.
- ○ B. Yes, the bank is next to impossible, it's on the next street.
- ○ C. Then it's next to impossible that you will call them tomorrow.

20. Your turn: speak

Tell me about something that is very difficult to do in your city or country.

on top of that

Expression · Level B1 · Neutral

In addition to something already mentioned, often something else annoying or surprising.

Tip: Use it to add one more point to a list of things, usually problems; it often starts a new clause, followed by a comma, and you can also say 'on top of this' or 'on top of everything'.

Amira: How was your move on Saturday?

Diego: Honestly, a mess. The van arrived two hours late.

Amira: Oh no. Was everything okay in the end?

Diego: Eventually. But the lift in the new building was broken, and on top of that, I had to carry the sofa up six floors.

Amira: Six floors? You must have been exhausted!

Diego: I could hardly walk on Sunday.

21. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "on top of that" mean?

- ○ A. Above that, on a higher floor
- ○ B. Instead of that, as a better choice
- ○ C. Because of that, as a result
- ○ D. Besides that, as another problem

22. Fill the gap

I missed my bus this morning, and _____, I left my phone at home.

23. Choose the best reply

Kofi: *My laptop crashed during the meeting, and I lost half my notes.*

- ○ A. Oh no! And on top of that, you probably had to present the next day.
- ○ B. Oh no! I'm sitting on top of that table, so I can't help you now.
- ○ C. Oh no! Please put your laptop on top of that, and it will be fine.

24. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a day when everything seemed to go wrong. What happened?

_____

_____

_____

or else

Expression · Level B1 · Casual

Used to say what bad thing will happen if you don't do something.

Tip: Put 'or else' after a command or warning, then say the result: 'Do X, or else Y will happen.' It can sound like a threat if you say it firmly, so use a light tone with friends.

Amira: Have you sent the group photos to everyone yet?

Ken: Not yet. I'll do it after dinner.

Amira: Please do it tonight. Upload them today, or else the shared link will expire.

Ken: Really? I thought it lasted a week.

Amira: It's only seven days from when I made it, and that was last Thursday.

Ken: Okay, okay. I'm opening my laptop now.

25. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "or else" mean?

- ○ A. Otherwise, something bad will happen
- ○ B. In a different place
- ○ C. Because Ken might forget
- ○ D. As well as that

26. Fill the gap

You should book the table now, _____ we won't get a seat on Saturday.

27. Choose the best reply

Olena: *I'm thinking of skipping the meeting tomorrow.*

- ○ A. You should go, or else your manager might think you're not interested.
- ○ B. Or else you can skip it, and then you will go.
- ○ C. Please don't, or else it will be like going.

28. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time you had to hurry to do something. What would have happened if you hadn't?

_____

_____

_____

put my foot down

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

To firmly refuse to allow something, or to insist on a rule.

Tip: Use it as 'put your/my/his foot down' (often with 'about' or 'when' + a situation); it suggests you were calm but firm after being patient for a while, and don't confuse it with 'put your foot in it', which means to say something embarrassing.

Amira: Did you ever sort out the noise from your upstairs neighbours?

Ken: Not yet. They still play loud music on weeknights, even after I asked nicely twice.

Amira: Twice? That's a lot of patience.

Ken: I know. Tomorrow I'm going to put my foot down and tell them it has to stop by ten o'clock.

Amira: Good. Just stay calm and be clear about it.

29. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "put my foot down" mean?

- ○ A. To give up and accept the situation
- ○ B. To make a polite request for the third time
- ○ C. To firmly insist that something must change or stop
- ○ D. To walk upstairs and knock on the door loudly

30. Fill the gap

My sister kept borrowing my car without asking, so last week I finally _____ and told her she needs permission first.

31. Choose the best reply

Olena: *The kids want to stay up until midnight again tonight, and they won't stop asking.*

- ○ A. I think you should put your foot down. They'll be so happy if you say yes.
- ○ B. I think you should put your foot down. It's a school night, so a firm no is fair.
- ○ C. I think you should put your foot in it. Just say what you like and hope for the best.

32. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you had to be strict with someone about a rule or a limit. What happened?

settle for

Phrasal verb | Level B2 | Neutral

To accept something that is less good than what you really wanted.

Tip: Use 'settle for' + noun or -ing (settle for a smaller flat, settle for waiting); it often follows a first choice that wasn't possible, and it's different from 'settle on', which means to finally choose something.

Amira: Did you get the laptop you wanted for university?

Kofi: Not exactly. The one I liked was sold out everywhere, and the next delivery isn't until January.

Amira: That's too late. So what did you do?

Kofi: I settled for the older model. It's a bit slower, but it was available and it's cheaper.

Amira: Honestly, that sounds sensible. You can always upgrade later.

33. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'settled for' mean?

- ○ A. Finally chose the best option after comparing many
- ○ B. Decided to wait until the better one was available
- ○ C. Accepted something less good than he first wanted
- ○ D. Paid for something in several smaller payments

34. Fill the gap

We wanted a flat near the city centre, but it was too expensive, so we had to _____ one a bit further out.

35. Choose the best reply

Olena: *Did you get the seat by the window on your flight?*

- ○ A. Yes, I settled for the aisle seat because it was my first choice.
- ○ B. No, they were all taken, so I settled for an aisle seat.
- ○ C. No, I settled for the window seat and I was very happy.

36. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a time when you couldn't get exactly what you wanted and had to accept something else.

swap out

Phrasal verb | Level B1 | Neutral

To swap something out is to remove it and put a different one in its place.

Tip: Use it as 'swap out A for B' or 'swap A out for B'; with a pronoun the object must go in the middle ('swap it out', not 'swap out it').

Amira: My laptop keeps overheating when I'm on video calls.

Ken: Have you checked the fan? Mine was clogged with dust.

Amira: I cleaned it, but it didn't help. The technician said the battery is the problem.

Ken: Then you should swap it out. A new battery isn't expensive.

Amira: True. I'll book it in for Saturday.

37. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does 'swap it out' mean?

- ○ A. Clean the battery carefully and use it again
- ○ B. Take the old battery out and put a new one in its place
- ○ C. Sell the laptop and buy a different one
- ○ D. Switch the laptop off for a while to let it cool down

38. Fill the gap

The bulb in the hallway keeps flickering, so I need to _____ for a new one.

39. Choose the best reply

Olena: *The zip on my backpack is completely broken, and I leave for the trip tomorrow.*

- ○ A. Can't you swap it out for your sister's old one?
- ○ B. Yes, I always swap out when my bag is broken.
- ○ C. Maybe you should swap out the trip to next week's zip.

40. Your turn: speak

Tell me about something you replaced because it stopped working well. What was it and why did you change it?

Answer key

it's on me

1. A. It was my mistake and I take responsibility.
2. it's on me
3. C. Yes, it's on me. I should have left earlier.
4. Example: Last year I forgot to book a hotel for a weekend trip with friends, and everything was full when I finally checked. I told them straight away, "It's on me, I should have done it weeks ago." We ended up staying in a small town nearby, and it actually turned out fine.

kick in

5. B. starts working or taking effect
6. kicks in
7. A. Give it a bit longer. It might not have kicked in yet.
8. Example: When I started going to the gym, I almost gave up after two weeks because I felt no different. But around the fourth week, the benefits really kicked in. I had more energy and I was sleeping much better.

the light bulb goes off

9. D. Diego suddenly understood what the problem was.
10. light bulb went off
11. B. Ah, so the light bulb went off, and now you know what to do differently.
12. Example: Last year I was learning to use a new accounting program at work, and nothing made sense for days. Then a colleague showed me one shortcut, and the light bulb went off. After that, I finished in an hour what had taken me a whole afternoon.

make it work

13. B. Find a way to manage the difficult situation and still succeed
14. make it work
15. B. Don't worry, we'll borrow some chairs and make it work.
16. Example: Last year I had to organise a small family dinner in a tiny flat, and we had far more guests than chairs. I borrowed some folding chairs from my neighbours and used the table in a different way, so we could make it work. It was a bit crowded, but everyone had a great evening.

next to impossible

17. C. Almost impossible; extremely difficult
18. next to impossible
19. A. I know, getting through to them is next to impossible.
20. Example: In my city, finding an affordable flat near the centre is next to impossible. Prices keep rising, and there are always dozens of people applying for the same place. Most of my friends end up living further out and commuting.

on top of that

21. D. Besides that, as another problem
22. on top of that
23. A. Oh no! And on top of that, you probably had to present the next day.
24. Example: Last winter I had a terrible day. I woke up late and missed my train, and on top of that, it was pouring with rain and I had no umbrella. I arrived at work soaking wet, but at least my colleagues made me a hot drink.

or else

25. A. Otherwise, something bad will happen
26. or else
27. A. You should go, or else your manager might think you're not interested.
28. Example: Last month I had to send an important form before noon, or else I would have lost my place on a course. I left the house early and finished it on my phone on the train. I was really relieved when I got the confirmation email.

put my foot down

29. C. To firmly insist that something must change or stop
30. put my foot down
31. B. I think you should put your foot down. It's a school night, so a firm no is fair.
32. Example: A few months ago my flatmate kept leaving dirty dishes in the sink for days. I was patient at first, but eventually I had to put my foot down and say we needed a cleaning schedule. It felt awkward, but it worked and the kitchen has been much better since.

settle for

33. C. Accepted something less good than he first wanted
34. settle for
35. B. No, they were all taken, so I settled for an aisle seat.
36. Example: Last year I wanted to book a hotel right next to the beach, but everything was fully booked for the holiday weekend. In the end I settled for a smaller place about twenty minutes away. It wasn't perfect, but the staff were friendly and we still had a great trip.

swap out

37. B. Take the old battery out and put a new one in its place
38. swap it out
39. A. Can't you swap it out for your sister's old one?
40. Example: Last year my phone screen cracked and the battery got really weak, so I decided to swap it out for a newer model. It wasn't cheap, but it made my daily life much easier because I use my phone for work.